

PONTIFICIA COMMISSIO BIBLICA

DE CHARACTERE HISTORICO
TRIUM PRIORUM CAPITUM GENESEOS

I. Utrum varia systemata exegetica, quae ad excludendum **sensum litteralem historicum** trium priorum capitum libri Geneseos excogitata et scientiae **fuco** propugnata sunt, solido fundamento fulcianur?

Resp. Negative.

II. Utrum **non obstantibus indole et forma historica libri Geneseos, peculiari trium priorum capitum inter se et cum sequentibus capitibus nexu, multiplici testimonio Scripturarum tum veteris tum novi Testamenti, unanimi fere sanctorum Patrum sententia ac traditionali sensu, quem, ab israelitico etiam populo transmissum, semper tenuit Ecclesia, doceri possit, praedita tria capita Geneseos continere non rerum vere gestarum narrationes, quae scilicet obiectivae realitati et historicae veritati respondeant; sed vel [a.] fabulosa ex veterum populorum mythologiis et cosmogoniis deprompta et ab auctore sacro, expurgato quovis polytheismi errore, doctrinae monotheisticae accommodata; vel [b.] allegorias et symbola, fundamento obiectivae realitatis destituta, sub historiae specie ad religiosas et philosophicas veritates inculandas proposita; vel tandem [c.] legendas ex parte historicas et ex parte fictitias ad animorum instructionem et aedificationem libere compositas?**

Resp. Negative ad utramque partem.

PONTIFICAL BIBLICAL COMMISSION

ON THE HISTORICAL CHARACTER OF THE FIRST 3
CHAPTERS OF GENESIS

I. Whether the various exegetical systems, which are thought up and defended **under a guise** of science, for excluding the **historical literal sense** of the first 3 books of Genesis are grounded with a solid foundation?

Resp. Negative.

II. **Notwithstanding the historic character and form of the book of Genesis, [and] the unique connection of the 3 chapters, among themselves and with subsequent chapters, [and] the manifold testimony of the Scriptures, both of the Old and of the New Testament, [and] the nearly unanimous opinion and traditional understanding of the holy Fathers [of the church], which the Church has always held, having been transmitted even from the Israelite people, . . .** Whether, it is able to be taught that the aforesaid 3 chapters of Genesis contain not **narrations of true deeds, namely, which would correspond to objective reality and to historical truth; but either [a.] fables derived from the mythologies and cosmogonies** of ancient peoples and put forth by the sacred author, purged of all error whatsoever of polytheism, and adapted to monotheistic doctrine; or [b.] **allegories and parables destitute of a foundation of objective reality**, published under an appearance of history, for inculcating religious and philosophical truths; or [c.] finally, **legends in part historic and in part fictitious**, composed creatively for the instruction and edification of souls?

Resp. Negative to each part [a., b., & c.]

III. Utrum speciatim **sensus litteralis historicus** vocari in dubium possit, ubi agitur de **factis** in eisdem capitibus **enarratis**, quae christianae religionis fundamenta attingunt: uti sunt, inter caetera, rerum universarum creatio a Deo facta in initio temporis; peculiaris creatio hominis; formatio primae mulieris ex primo homine; generis humani unitas; originalis protoparentum felicitas in statu iustitiae, integritatis et immortalitatis; praeceptum a Deo homini datum ad eius obedientiam probandam; divini praecepti, diabolo sub serpentis specie suasore, transgressio; protoparentum deiectio ab illo primaevo innocentiae statu; nec non Reparatoris futuri promissio?

Resp. Negative.

IV. Utrum in interpretandis illis horum capitum locis, quos Patres et Doctores diverso modo intellexerunt, quin certi quippiam definitique tradiderint, liceat, salvo Ecclesiae iudicio servataque fidei analogia, eam quam quisque prudenter probaverit, sequi tuerique sententiam?

Resp. Affirmative.

V. Utrum omnia et singula, verba videlicet et phrases, quae in praedictis capitibus occurrunt, semper et necessario accipienda sint **sensu proprio**, ita ut ab eo discedere numquam liceat, etiam cum [a.] locutiones ipsae manifesto appareant **improprie, seu metaphorice vel anthropomorphice, usurpatae**, et [b.] sensum proprium vel [i.] ratio tenere prohibeat vel [ii.] necessitas cogat dimittere?

Resp. Negative.

III. Whether, in particular, **the literal historic sense** may be called into doubt, where[ever] in the aforesaid **narrated** chapters **facts** are treated which touch upon the foundations of the Christian religion: as are, among others, [a.] God's creation of all things at the beginning of time; [b.] the formation of the first woman out of the first man; [c.] the unity of mankind; [d.] the original blessedness of [our] proto-parents in a state of justice, integrity and immortality; [e.] God's commandment given to man to test his obedience; [f.] the transgression of the divine precept, with the devil under the appearance of a serpent as the temptor; [g.] the fall of the proto-parents from that pristine state of innocence; [h.] no less than the promise of a future Reparator ?

Resp. Negative.

IV. Whether, in these chapters' places needing to be interpreted, which the Fathers and Doctors differinglly understood, it may be allowed, while preserving the judgment[al rights] of the church and the analogy of faith, to follow and defend that opinion which a person will have prudently tested, so long as they have not betrayed away anything certain or defined?

Resp. Affirmative.

V. Whether each and every one of the individual words and phrases, which occur in the aforesaid chapters, always and necessarily are to be taken in the[ir own] **proper sense**, in this way that it may never be permitted to depart from it, even when [a.] the expressions themselves appear [to have been expressed] manifestly **improperly, usurped either metaphorically or anthropomorphically**; and [b. when] either [i.] reason may rule out, or [ii.] necessity may force the dismissing of the proper sense ?

VI. Utrum, praesupposito litterali et historico sensu, nonnullorum locorum eorundem capitum **interpretatio allegorica et prophetica**, praefulgente sanctorum Patrum et Ecclesiae ipsius exemplo, adhiberi sapienter et utiliter possit?

Resp. Affirmative.

VII. Utrum, cum in conscribendo primo Geneseos capite non fuerit sacri auctoris mens intimam adspettabilium rerum constitutionem ordinemque creationis completum scientifico more docere; sed potius suae genti tradere notitiam popularem, prout communis sermo per ea ferebat tempora, sensibus et captui hominum accommodatam, sit in horum interpretatione adamussim semperque investiganda scientifici sermonis proprietas?

Resp. Negative.

VIII. Utrum in illa sex dierum denominatione atque distinctione, de quibus in Geneseos capite primo, sumi possit vox *Yom* (dies), sive sensu proprio pro die naturali, sive sensu improprio pro quodam temporis spatio, deque huiusmodi quaestione libere inter exegetas disceptare liceat?

Resp. Affirmative.

Resp. Negative.

VI. Presupposing a literal and historical sense [to exist], whether, an [additional] **allegorical or prophetic interpretation** of some places of the same chapters may be wisely and usefully applied, in light of the splendid example [of similar allegorical and prophetic interpretations] of the holy Fathers and of the Church herself?

Resp. Affirmative.

VII. Since, in the jointly-to-be-composed [by both God and man] first chapter of Genesis, it was not the mind of the sacred author to teach, in a scientific way, the intimate construction of visible things and a complete ordering of creation; but rather to deliver to his people a popular understanding, adapted to the perceptions and understanding of men, in the way that common opinion was occurring in those days; whether there should always and exactly be investigated the correctness of scientific opinion, in the interpretation of these [chapters]?

Resp. Negative.

VII. Whether the [Hebrew] expression *Yom* (day) may be taken, from that numbering and distinction of 6 days in the 1st chapter of Genesis, either **in the proper sense** for a natural day, or **in an improper sense** for a certain space of time, and whether it may be permitted, among exegetes, to freely dispute about a question of this sort?

Resp. Affirmative.

*Die autem 30 Iunii anni 1909, in audientia ambobus R.mis
Consultoribus ab actis benigne concessa, Sanctissimus
praedicta responsa rata habuit ac publici iuris fieri mandavit.*

Romae, die 30 Iunii 1909.

Fulcranus Vigouroux, P.S.S.
Laurentius Janssens, O.S.B.
Consultores ab Actis.

*Now on June 30, of the year 1909, in an audience happily
granted to both the highly Rev. Consultor[-Secretarie]s about
[their commission's] acts, his Holiness had the aforesaid
responses recorded, and commanded them to become part of
public law [/ policy].*

Romae, die 30 Iunii 1909.

Fulcranus Vigouroux, P.S.S.
Laurentius Janssens, O.S.B.
Consultores ab Actis.